Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Wordsworth's "[Most sweet it is with unuplifted eyes]"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used by the contestant in a discussion of the effect, as described in Wordsworth's "[Most sweet it is with unuplifted eyes]," that a walk through the natural world can have on a person's imagination include

alliteration,
diction,
iamb,
imagery,
metaphor,
meter,
reification,
rhyme scheme,
simile,
sonnet,
spondee, and
tone.

Please note that the successful analysis will address not only Wordsworth's appreciation of nature as a source of influence on the imagination but will draw on this sonnet specifically in order to support the essay's thesis. The writer might mention at some point that Wordsworth is both a poet of nature and a poet of humanity.

The young essayist might point directly to line 2's "if path be there or none" to suggest that it is the person's individual encounter, whether he or she is the first one into that "fair region" or not, that is important; however, it is line 4's "Which he forbears" that serves to isolate the person's (perhaps the poet's) imagination—his or her Fancy (line 6)—from the immediate effects of being in nature. The person's/poet's own "work of Fancy" or "meditation" (5-6) is temporally framed by simply being in nature "between / The beauty coming and the beauty gone" (7-8) encountered while walking.

The young writer might note that something of a turn occurs with line 9: the conditional "If [. . . then] / Let us break off all commerce with the Muse" (9-10), which exhorts the person walking to turn to Thought and Love (arguably the reification of naturally, unaffected occurring aspects of being human) and to allow the senses in their encountering (or refusal to encounter actively) nature to act as inspiration for a poem to be composed.